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“Assassin’s Creed reminds us that history is human experience”: Students’ senses of empathy while playing a narrative video game

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ABSTRACT

Research into students’ interactions with historical video games is limited and tends to focus on teacher mediation. As a result, little is known about the meanings that students independently construct as they consume this form of media. This qualitative interview study uses *Assassin’s Creed*, a narrative video game with a historical setting, as a site of inquiry. Students described a sense of immediate access to history that contrasted with school-based learning, a sense of human connection to people in the past, and increased perception of multiple perspectives in history. They also evidenced a willingness to allow the games to rewrite their beliefs about history, and theorized about the games’ historical accuracy. However, students tended to miss opportunities for critical engagement with this visceral sense of immersive experience. As such, implications are raised regarding ways to promote critical investigation into gameplay experiences as well as the importance of fostering a sense of human connection to history through social education.

KEYWORDS

Video games; *Assassin’s Creed*; narrative video games; historical empathy; affective engagement

Research into video games and social education is fairly sparse, particularly regarding the messages students receive from their interactions with games set in historical time periods (Metzger & Paxton, 2016; Tobias & Fletcher, 2012; Young, Slota, & Lai, 2012). While research into video games and learning has expanded dramatically in recent years (Goldberg & Larsson, 2015; Heineman, 2015), within the field of social education specifically, the literature is still in the relatively early stages of development (Metzger & Paxton, 2016). For many social studies educators, video games may often be what Reichmuth and Werning (2006) called a “neglected media,” those which “exhibit strong popular appeal and economic relevance, contrasted by a lack of cultural prestige and scientific coverage” (p. 47).

Such relative neglect seems strange given the rate at which students engage with the medium; a national survey conducted by the Pew Research Center found that 97% of teens ages 12 to 17 (99% of boys and 94% of girls) regularly play games on various electronic platforms (e.g., consoles, computers, and smartphones) (Lenhart et al., 2008). The Entertainment Software Association (2017) reported in 2017 that 67% of U.S. households own a device that is used to play video games, and 65% of U.S. households have at least one person who plays three or more

hours of video games each week. Students, therefore, experience a high rate of exposure to the portrayals of worlds and peoples represented in games.

This exposure coincides with positive emotional associations, as gaming also plays a significant role in students' social lives. The Entertainment Software Association (2017) reported that 54% of the "most frequent gamers say that video games help connect them with their friends" (p. 8). Similarly, Lenhart, Smith, Anderson, Duggan, and Perrin (2015) found that video games play a critical role in the development and maintenance of teenage boys' friendships. These social factors have significant effects on student learning. The Pew Internet and American Life Project concluded that the social component of gameplay means that video games serve as a ground for various forms of civic learning, from working collaboratively with others to exploring social, moral, and ethical issues in a virtual environment (Lenhart et al., 2008). Further, in their review of the literature on the psychological benefits of video games, Granic, Lobel, and Engels (2014) noted that even violent games whose mechanisms rely on cooperation rather than competition are regularly found to increase prosocial behavior and decrease aggression.

It is, therefore, important for social studies teachers to understand the historical messages that these teenage students absorb in their out-of-classroom gaming experiences. As Metzger and Paxton (2016) wrote,

An important motivation for our work is the distinct possibility that much of what students today "know" about the past may come not from teachers, textbooks, or tests but from popular-culture media, such as video games. History educators should be aware of how video games may influence young people's thinking about the past that they bring as background into the classroom. (p. 2)

As this line of inquiry develops, it is important to define what "learning" means in this typically out-of-classroom setting. The limited literature that exists regarding video games and social education tends to focus on a similarly limited definition of learning, that of content acquisition. Most studies to date have focused on the knowledge gained by students as they complete the mechanisms of a particular game (McDonald & Hannafin, 2003; Squire, DeVane, & Durga, 2008). For example, Moshirnia and Israel (2010) modified versions of popular commercial games for "educational" purposes, defined as helping students acquire content knowledge. The success rate of this enterprise varies by discipline and is overall doubtful (Young, Slota, Cutter, et al., 2012).

Yet, "treating games as content transmission systems as opposed to tools to think with" (Squire, 2004, p. 10) is only one way of considering the learning potential of games. This point is particularly important in social education. For example, Squire (2004) suggested that the value of the simulation game *Civilization* is found in the ways it affords students opportunities for experimentation with historical cause and effect, not in whether it teaches students an accurate timeline of world history. As counterfactuals can be useful for learning history (Roberts, 2011), games in which students' choices can lead to outcomes other than those in the historical record may provide learning experiences of particular interest for social educators.

Different genres of historical games may lead to different possibilities for social education (McCall, 2016; Metzger & Paxton, 2016). In this study, I focus on *Assassin's Creed* (Ubisoft, 2007–2018), a narrative video game franchise set in various historical time periods, in order to explore the premise that this genre might provide learning

opportunities analogous to those fostered by historical films. Despite increasing research in the area, fairly little is known regarding the ways students may internalize the implicit and explicit messages embedded in the medium of historical video games (Metzger & Paxton, 2016; Tobias & Fletcher, 2012; Young et al., 2012). This lacuna is striking given that video games often make use of historical settings, characters, and plots.

To address this gap, in this study I examine how students' perceptions of historical peoples and time periods may be influenced by the depictions they encounter in *Assassin's Creed*. My research question was the following: "In what ways does playing *Assassin's Creed* influence students' perceptions of the past?" To answer this question, I paid particular attention to describing the ways students received and processed the historical characters and stories present in the games. By taking this approach, I responded to Metzger and Paxton's (2016) call for more research on students' gameplay experiences, especially "how the historical narratives they construct through gameplay prompt them to talk about connections between the past, the world today, and their own lives" (p. 27).

Narrative in video games and narrative video games

Storytelling and plot development are important to the success of video games (Lucas, 2015). Compared with other media, such as books or film, video games are distinct in that the stories they tell happen in the interplay between the programming code and the user (Rouse, 2001). Because of this interactive element, literary scholars have debated the extent to which video games may be analyzed according to traditional understandings of narrative. Mukherjee (2015) summarized this discussion as being concerned with "whether the ephemeral text, which the player plays out and changes with each gameplay, can be analysed at all" (p. 103). As such, some literary scholars have argued that video games represent a unique genre that should be understood on its own terms. For example, Aarseth (2004) described quest games (i.e., adventure games in which players take on roles, explore a virtual world, and accomplish tasks) as a "post-narrative discourse." Likewise, Ulaş (2014) suggested that the virtual environments created by game designers may be considered storytelling elements in their own right.

Other literary scholars have found that interpretive difficulties are resolved when video game narratives are understood as complex structures. Wolf (2001) noted that video games "open up new possibilities in narrative construction" (p. 110) and described both linear and branching structures in game narratives. Linear structures represent a traditional approach to storytelling, in which the story progresses from beginning to end in a straightforward way "with one chain of events leading to a single outcome" (Wolf, 2001, p. 107). In contrast, branching structures exist when the player's actions can change the course of the story, creating "multiple directions, leading to different sets of consequences" (Wolf, 2001, p. 108). Branches may offer multiple paths to the same outcome or may lead to multiple outcomes. Carlquist (2002) found that linear stories allow game designers to give "psychological depth" to the game narrative (p. 43), whereas branching stories offer opportunities for player interaction. Writing in 2002, he predicted that game designers would increasingly combine these two structures. Indeed, *Assassin's Creed*, which debuted in 2007, fulfilled this prediction. Ultimately, Carlquist (2002) found that video games are about *playing* stories rather than *reading* them, an observation that fits

well with Mukherjee's (2015) description of video game consoles as "storyplaying" devices rather than storytelling ones (p. 46).

The above principles apply to a wide range of video game genres but are particularly important for this study's focus on *Assassin's Creed*, which is classified as a narrative video game. Video games with historical settings span a wide range of genres, from first-person shooters (e.g., *Call of Duty*) to strategy games (e.g., *Civilization*). Narrative games tell a story through a combination of missions and "cutscenes" (i.e., cinematic interludes). Both missions and cutscenes serve to advance the plot. Some missions are required to be completed in a certain order, whereas others (known as "side quests") can be undertaken at any time or ignored completely. Players take on a role as a character (or, sometimes, switch between multiple viewpoints in the story) and make choices about how to engage with the digital world, although in most cases (including the case of *Assassin's Creed*) the plot can only turn out one way. The gameplay experience, therefore, is in some ways akin to reading a novel or watching a film and in other ways akin to role-playing or historical reenactment. Narrative games represent a distinct genre that is increasingly theorized by game scholars (Aarseth, 1997; Carlquist, 2002; Chapman, 2010; Ensslin, 2014; Juul, 1999; Mukherjee, 2015; Murray, 1997; Ryan, 2006), with a line of questioning examining the ways games with historical settings may represent an emerging form of historiography (Aurell, 2015; Chapman, Foka, & Westin, 2017; de Groot, 2009; Rejack, 2007; Spring, 2015; Taylor & Whalen, 2008; Therrien, 2015).

This combination of activities—absorbing a narrative while taking part in it—has particular impacts on the player, especially as players are known to experience a shift in their self-perception to identify strongly with the characters they embody (Klimmt, Hefner, & Vorderer, 2009). Gee (2011) argued that narrative video games offer chances for human sense making and perspective taking and, as such, they "have the potential to create empathy for other people's situations and perspectives in life" (p. 353). When players inhabit a virtual world via an avatar (i.e., onscreen character), they not only imagine a different life but also take action as though they were, in fact, living this alternate life. Reflecting on his own gaming experiences, Gee (2011) indicated that playing narrative video games "expands [his] storytelling capacity in terms of empathy and respect for the world and others" (p. 356). The examples Gee provided mostly center on the present day—for example, learning via the game *SWAT4* some of the complexities of daily work for SWAT team members. In this article, I explore the possibility that a similar principle may be true when students play *Assassin's Creed*: By inhabiting and taking action in an imagined past via a character, students likely develop empathy for the circumstances of people in history.

Previous studies of video games for social education

Most research involving video games and social education focuses on the teacher's perspective (e.g., Berger & Staley, 2014; McCall, 2011, 2014, 2016; Wainwright, 2014). Few empirical studies exist that examine K–12 students' gameplay experiences from a social education perspective. Of these, only one examines students' social studies learning based on the interaction of narrative and gameplay. Akkerman, Admiraal, and Huizenga (2009) studied secondary students who played a multimedia game designed to teach them about medieval Amsterdam. The game was distinct in that, rather than

presenting students with a series of facts to memorize, its structure encouraged students to understand the history of Amsterdam as a narrative via characters they met in the game. The researchers found that the game encouraged students to engage in three types of storification: receiving (spectating), constructing (directing), and participating (acting). In particular, the active nature of constructing and participating led to greater knowledge of the game's story and, thereby, the history of medieval Amsterdam.

Indeed, the active nature of gaming—participating in a story rather than receiving it—has often drawn attention by researchers. Thus, it is not surprising that many studies have emphasized the power of games to promote student engagement. Such studies have indicated that video games may be useful for promoting interest in social studies as a discipline. Squire et al. (2008) implemented *Civilization III*, a simulation game in which students experiment with strategies to 'advance' a civilization, in an after-school program for disadvantaged middle school students who perceived school as "something to be endured" (p. 242). The researchers found that these students' interest in social studies increased as a result of the after-school video game program and suggested that gameplay may serve as a gateway to "more academically valued practices such as reading or watching documentaries" (p. 249). Watson, Mong, and Harris (2011) studied a high school history class that played an educational game entitled *Making History*. Results showed that integrating gameplay into class sessions promoted a student-centered environment and generated interest in the course content.

Other studies have inquired into the content-centered learning that takes place. These studies have tended to emphasize the importance of the teacher's role in mediating game-based learning. Lynch, Mallon, and Connolly (2015) studied the use of *Plunkett's Pages*, an alternate-reality game designed to teach about the 1916 Easter Rising, with secondary students in Ireland. They found that students improved their knowledge of the historical event but benefitted from debriefing to clarify which game characters were historical figures and which were fictional. The researchers concluded that there is an "absolute necessity for post-game reflective discussions to take place in order to disentangle factual and fictional elements and complement the learning experience" (p. 35). Lee and Probert (2010) studied an 11th-grade class that played *Civilization III* and found that the game reinforced analytical concepts taught in class. For example, students came to understand more keenly the significance of geography in the development of a city. The researchers concluded that it was essential for games to be "used in combination with other activities including teacher lecture, background readings, class discussion and critical analysis" in order to maximize student learning (p. 24). Egenfeldt-Nielsen (2005) utilized the game *Europa Universalis II* in a Danish high school class. Based on his students' struggles to connect their gameplay experiences with their knowledge of history, he emphasized the need for teacher-directed goals and guidance.

Whereas these studies emphasized the importance of teachers in ensuring student learning, the present study focuses on students' unmediated interactions with a game. As such, the study adds to the literature by providing a portrait of the meanings that students independently construct via their interactions with a narrative video game with a historical setting.

Theoretical framework

This research focus raises a question: What definition of empathy is the most useful for evaluating students' interactions with a narrative video game? Is the type of empathy that Gee (2011) described resonant with goals in social education?

At first glance, the answer may seem to be no. Definitions of historical empathy in social education, while widely variable (Brooks, 2009), have tended to downplay the salience of emotion. Foster and Yeager (1998) were adamant that historical empathy does not involve imagination, overidentification, or sympathy, even to the point of saying that encouraging students to sympathize with victims of slavery would be a misuse of the concept. The literature has evidenced a concern that students may erroneously conclude that the emotions they feel are identical to those of people in the past—a pitfall labeled as “presentism,” what Wineburg (2001) summarized as “the act of viewing the past through the lens of the present” (p. 19). Many researchers have cautioned teachers that affective connections are a danger for historical literacy due to the risk of presentism (Lévesque, 2008; Nokes, 2013; VanSledright, 2011; Wineburg, 2001). Cognitive, rather than affective, perspective-taking is thus the order of the day; Lee and Ashby (2001) wrote that “historical empathy and rational understanding, in this sense, are different names for an *achievement*” (p. 24, emphasis in original).

This cognitive achievement is understood as a counterintuitive one. Wineburg’s (2001) famous description of historical thinking as an “unnatural act” is rooted in his observation that presentist thinking “comes quite naturally” (p. 19). Nokes (2013) similarly cautioned teachers that helping students avoid presentism means adopting pedagogical moves that may feel unnatural: “Teaching in a manner that discourages unrestrained personal connections and reactions cuts against the grain of traditional learning theories ... what on the surface appears to be good teaching might actually be ahistorical thinking, interfering with historical literacies” (p. 125). Here, Nokes’s choice of language to refer to students’ emotions—“unrestrained personal connections and reactions” (p. 125)—illustrates the distrust that seems to underlie many researchers’ view of affective engagement in perspective-taking, itself reflecting a pervasive discounting of emotion in many forms of educational research (Boler, 1999; Sheppard, Katz, & Grosland, 2015).

However, in recent years the consensus that emotional engagement equals a lack of rigor has been shaken. While it is true that historians are skeptical of claims about emotion and the limits of perspective-taking more broadly (Lévesque, 2008), a more recent argument is that wholly erasing emotion from empathy represents a second pitfall. Thus, an alternate strain of social education research has sought to re-integrate emotion into the concept of empathy in ways that maintain criticality in reasoning through the past (Barton & Levstik, 2004; Endacott, 2010; Endacott & Brooks, 2013). As early as 2004, Barton and Levstik explicitly rejected the idea that affective engagement leads to presentism. While they agreed that imagining the emotions of others *as though they were one’s own* represents a problem for historical reasoning, they reminded readers that this action should rightly be categorized as *sympathy* rather than *empathy*. Further, Endacott and Brooks (2013) suggested that “students must be able to find an affective connection between the experiences faced by historical figures and similar experiences in their own lives” as one of the skills necessary for historical empathy (p. 46). They indicated that this approach to historical empathy “can help students develop a stronger awareness of needs around them and a sense of agency to respond to these needs” (p. 45). Likewise, recent theorizing on empathy in the field of public history has suggested that valuing museum visitors’ emotional responses can help them develop a sense of human connection to history, become more aware of those like and unlike themselves, and thereby deepen mutual understanding among individuals from different social groups today (Gockigdem, 2016). Arnold-de-Simine (2013) offered that the emotional component of

empathy is often viewed as an “ethically constructive response” to the museum’s mediation of memory (p. 2). Valuing the way public historians think about empathy seems especially salient for the case of *Assassin’s Creed*, which is not intended as an academic text but would be categorized under the umbrella of popular history.

Thus, for the purposes of this study, I adopted Barton and Levstik’s (2004) two-part definition of historical empathy as perspective recognition and care. This decision follows the lead of Marcus, Metzger, Paxton, and Stoddard (2010), who investigated the influence of historical films on students’ development of historical empathy. I observed that a parallel could be drawn between the genre of historical films and the genre of narrative video games in that both feature a deeply immersive world depicted by both visual and auditory cues in which characters interact and a plot unfolds. Just as a strong understanding of historical empathy should push students to discern presentist aspects of historical feature films (Metzger, 2007), a similar need exists for students as they process their experiences with historical video games. Therefore, I reasoned that a similar definition of empathy would prove the most salient for the two settings.

Here, I will offer a brief overview of Barton and Levstik’s (2004) framework. Perspective recognition, the component most easily recognized by academic historians, comprises five parts: *a sense of otherness*, to recognize the differences between ourselves and people in the past; *shared normalcy*, to recognize our similarities; *historical contextualization*, to place specific events in the broader context of their time; *multiplicity of historical perspectives*, to avoid painting people in the past with a single, broad brush; and *contextualization of the present*, to recognize that the present represents its own historical context and does not form an objective perch from which to view the past.

However, Barton and Levstik (2004) indicated that these components, while necessary, are not sufficient for a definition of historical empathy in the context of social education. An additional ingredient is needed: that of care. Barton and Levstik insisted that care is not only “the motivating force behind nearly all historical research” (p. 228) but also essential for the higher purposes of social education:

Limiting empathy to a purely cognitive endeavor limits its contribution to pluralist democracy. To engage in meaningful deliberation with those whose ideas differ from our own, we must do more than understand them—we must care about them and their perspectives. (p. 207)

Barton and Levstik’s definition of care as a component of historical empathy includes four aspects: *caring about*, being able to identify what one wants to learn about in history; *caring that*, forming a basis for making moral judgments about what happened; *caring for*, establishing a sense of compassion for people in the past (even though it is impossible to help them); and *caring to*, developing a willingness to apply what has been learned from history to the present. For the purposes of this study, including care in the definition of historical empathy helped bridge the gap between academic and popular history—an essential step for a study whose site was a video game rather than a classroom.

The *Assassin’s Creed* franchise

Known for its rich, immersive depictions of historical time periods, the *Assassin’s Creed* series is often referenced in the social education literature as having potential for history education

(Berger & Staley, 2014; Chapman, 2013; Gilbert, 2017; Metzger & Paxton, 2016; Wainwright, 2014; Young Slota, Cutter, et al., 2012). Likewise, the series has drawn the attention of researchers in the humanities (Dow, 2013; El-Nasr, Al-Saati, Niedenthal, & Milam, 2008; Hammar, 2017; Komel, 2014; Leith & Fordham, 2017). Far from a niche title, *Assassin's Creed* is recognized as a major franchise, with 11 major titles and a feature film to its credit; in September 2016, Ubisoft announced that the series had sold over 100 million copies worldwide (Kerr, 2016). This figure has continued to grow, as its 2018 release, *Odyssey*, set the record for sales in the franchise's current generation (Workman, 2018), thereby eclipsing sales of the previous year's release, *Origins*, which itself had doubled those of the previous title, *Syndicate* (Tassi, 2017). Its passionate fan base routinely discusses storylines, investigates the accuracy of historical depictions, and catalogues historical and fictional characters on online fora such as assassinscreed.wikia.com. While the series is rated "M for Mature" (i.e., ages 17 and up), *Assassin's Creed* has increasingly been marketed to children in recent years (Sinclair, 2014), and with its 2017 title, *Origins*, the franchise announced a "discovery tour" mode intended to allow teachers to utilize the game as a "combat-free living museum" in their classrooms (Webster, 2017, para. 2). Taken together, these research- and popularity-based factors provide evidence that *Assassin's Creed* represents a significant cultural product worthy of examination in social education research.

A brief overview of the series will be helpful for framing the findings of this study. The premise of *Assassin's Creed* hinges on an elaborate science fiction conceit in which technology allows people to access the "genetic memories" of their ancestors. In each game, a present-day character enters the memories of a person who lived in a previous time period. While the settings are often recognizable, the main character usually offers a different vantage point from that which is typically present in the social studies curriculum. For example, *Assassin's Creed III* frames the American Revolution from a Native American perspective via the main character of Ratonnhaké:ton, also known as Connor.

These main characters are often emotionally compelling and are developed as the plot unfolds. Their fictional stories are intertwined with real historical events in a way that "take[s] advantage of the inherent ambiguity of history instead of blatantly altering it" (Leith & Fordham, 2017, p. 11). Exploring historical settings and meeting historical figures are part of the draw; Ubisoft, the company that produces *Assassin's Creed*, regularly releases advertisements for the series that celebrate its attention to historical detail (Gilbert, 2017; Metzger & Paxton, 2016). For instance, Ubisoft employed a historian with knowledge of Kanien'keha:ka culture on a full-time basis to help inform the development of the character Ratonnhaké:ton/Connor and hired native Mohawk speakers for voiceovers in *Assassin's Creed III* (Clark, 2012; Leith & Fordham, 2017). Gameplay is centered on moving the story forward, and players must be purposeful in the strategies they employ to accomplish missions. While *Assassin's Creed* is designed for entertainment rather than education, it is significant that students who play are choosing to immerse themselves in a historically themed environment for hours at a time. In this study, I explore the way students independently engage with the historical messages they encounter as they do so.

Methods

Data collection

This study utilizes semistructured qualitative interviews (Kvale, 1996; Weiss, 1994) conducted in spring 2016 with 14 participants, all high school students (grades 9 through 12) enrolled at Catholic College Preparatory Academy (pseudonym), a private boys' school in a mid-size Midwestern city. While I had hoped to draw from a mixed-gender group, especially as high school girls are estimated to make up 11% of all gamers (Entertainment Software Association, 2017), I discovered that most school administrators were reluctant to open their doors to a video game researcher due to negative perceptions of video games in the context of education. The franchise name *Assassin's Creed*, which for many adults connoted gratuitous violence, added to this difficulty, particularly given a contemporary background of frequent school shootings and media commentary tying video games to real-world bloodshed.¹ As a result, my attempts at gaining access to public, mixed-gender schools failed. Fortunately, I was able to draw on my Jesuit university's connections with local Catholic schools. Of these, one boys' high school agreed to participate, although, perhaps similarly skeptical about the educational value of video games, they limited my access to students to one interview each. In this sense, my participants represented a strangely inconvenient "convenience" sample, a reality evident in other video game educational researchers' descriptions of their methods (e.g., Squire, 2004).

However, once I had gained access to a school, I employed purposive sampling, which is the deliberate choice of participants due to the qualities they possess (Patton, 2015). The quality I chose to focus on was their experience with the *Assassin's Creed* series. A teacher sent out a survey on my behalf to the full student body, asking about which (if any) *Assassin's Creed* games they had played and how far they had gotten with each title. Out of approximately 1,000 students in the school, 54 students responded to the survey. Although I had hoped to center the study on *Syndicate*, then the most recent *Assassin's Creed* release, the survey results revealed that few students had devoted much time to this title (a trend that corresponded with *Syndicate's* relatively low sales numbers). However, *Assassin's Creed III* emerged as the most popular title, with 18 students who had fully completed the game. I therefore chose to rewrite the interview protocol, reasoning that a focus on *Assassin's Creed III* would not only provide access to a larger pool of potential interviewees but also offer more crossover with social studies curricula (as the Revolutionary War, the setting for *Assassin's Creed III*, is more frequently discussed in American schools than industrial-era London, the setting for *Syndicate*).

I contacted the 18 students with a request for an interview, and 14 agreed to participate in the study. Of these, six were seniors, three were juniors, and five were freshmen. Three identified as Latino and the rest identified as White. While they all described other video games they enjoyed playing, these students were particularly avid in their appreciation for *Assassin's Creed*. All had beaten the game *Assassin's Creed III*, and most had beaten multiple other titles in the franchise. Some had beaten every major title, and many reported replaying titles they had found particularly meaningful. This study sample, therefore, comprised students who had logged substantial time with *Assassin's Creed* (one website that compiles completion times indicates that major titles take 30–60 hours each [Gamelengths, 2016]) and could speak from a deep knowledge of the series. As such, the population comprised what Patton (2015) called "critical cases," an approach to

qualitative research characterized by the selection of a small number of important cases likely to “yield the most information and have the greatest impact on the development of knowledge” (p. 276). This participant group was able to provide particularly rich data, but their experiences do not reflect the results that might be seen in students with more cursory engagement with the *Assassin’s Creed* franchise, and the validity of the study’s results should be understood within this scope. Finally, participants’ in-class social studies experiences included two courses in global history and one course in American history, with electives possible in anthropology, archaeology, economics, politics, and psychology. The social studies department stated that it hoped to “foster a concern for justice” and “consideration for how Christian principles apply to the real world” in addition to developing skills in critical thinking, problem solving, and citizenship. Table 1 summarizes participants’ experiences with *Assassin’s Creed* and their school’s social studies curriculum, using pseudonyms that students selected to protect their anonymity.

Following the school’s stipulations, I conducted one interview with each participant. Interviews lasted between 25 and 95 minutes, with an average length of 51 minutes. In the interviews, I asked students to recount historical events from various game characters’ perspectives, reflect on the meaning they found in their gameplay experiences, and evaluate the differences they perceived between their gameplay and school-based experiences. The interview protocol is included as an appendix. I also built rapport by sharing my own gameplay experiences with *Assassin’s Creed*. In total, 716 minutes of recorded interviews were transcribed for analysis. These transcripts form the primary data source for this study. Additional sources, which allowed for triangulation, include researcher memos written while playing *Assassin’s Creed III* and *Assassin’s Creed: Syndicate*, supplemental materials created by Ubisoft (such as an encyclopedia [Cuny, 2012], art collections [McVittie, 2012; Miller, 2015], and guides to assist players in completing the game’s missions [such as Piggyback Interactive Limited, 2012]), and online materials created by fans (such as assassinscreed.wikia.com and YouTube videos).

Data analysis

My analysis was guided by an inductive approach following Creswell’s (2009) “data analysis spiral” (p. 150), which consisted of organizing, reading, reflecting, and comparing the interview transcripts. In the reading phase, I drew from narrative inquiry (Chase, 2011), which understands stories told by subjects as “portal[s] through which a person enters the world and by which their experience of the world is interpreted and made personally meaningful” (Connelly & Clandinin, 2006, p. 375). In this case, I wanted to understand the stories students told about their gameplay experiences in order to surface the meaning they found in their interactions with characters and plotlines. Understanding subjects’ gameplay experiences on their own terms seemed particularly important as video games (and the people who play them) are often stereotyped and dismissed.

My process followed Josselson (2011). First, I read each transcript on its own and sought to identify the main themes present in each student’s reflections. I assigned individual codes to each interview to investigate these themes and used these codes to identify key passages in the transcripts. I then examined these passages individually to allow them to re-inform my understanding of the whole, a process that follows Schleiermacher’s hermeneutic circle (Denzin, 2005). For example, one of the major themes

Table 1. Summary of participants.

Pseudonym	Grade	No. of titles beaten	No. of titles partially completed	High school social studies courses taken	Self-described interest in social studies
Alberto	Senior (12)	5	2	• AP Comparative Government • AP World History • AP U.S. History • Global History I and II	Moderate
Gareth	Senior (12)	7	1	• AP Psychology • AP U.S. History • Global History I and II	Moderate
James	Senior (12)	9	0	• Economics • American History • Global History I and II	Low
Joseph	Senior (12)	9	0	• Microeconomics and Macroeconomics • AP Modern European History • AP Psychology • AP Comparative Government • AP U.S. Government • AP U.S. History • Global History I and II	High
Toby	Senior (12)	4	1	• U.S. Government • American History • Global History I and II	Low
Todd	Senior (12)	6	2	• American History • Global History I and II	Low
Adam	Junior (11)	6	0	• AP U.S. History • AP World History • Global History I	Low
Charlie	Junior (11)	1	3	• American History • Global History I and II	Low
Michael	Junior (11)	2	0	• AP U.S. History • AP World History • Global History I	Moderate
Alessandro	Freshman (9)	4	4	• Global History I	Moderate
Ethan	Freshman (9)	3	1	• Global History I	Moderate
George	Freshman (9)	2	1	• Global History I	Low
Henry	Freshman (9)	4	2	• Global History I	Low
Liam	Freshman (9)	9	0	• Global History I	High

in Gareth's interview was humanity in portrayals of historical figures; a passage that illustrates this theme is his musing over whether George Washington enjoyed eating blackberries. Similarly, a major theme in Liam's interview was personal connection with historical figures; one passage that illustrates this theme is his discussion of how the portrayal of Pope Alexander VI in *Assassin's Creed II* prompted reflection on his own Catholic identity.

Having gained an understanding of the stories each student told about his interactions with the games, I turned to the comparing phase of Creswell's spiral to determine which themes were consistent across all 14 interviews. I utilized open coding (Charmaz, 2010) and constant-comparative coding to capture similarities and differences. For example, the code of "immersion" (defined as a sense of having been present in a historical setting) was present across the interviews, but each student described and evaluated this virtual experience differently. Then, I moved from open to axial codes and grouped the data into categories as I tentatively began to establish relationships between the data. For example, as I came to understand students' theorizing about historical accuracy, I perceived a connection between their awareness of the games as a created narrative and their frequent trust in game designers. Along the way, I flagged particularly vivid stories articulated by various participants, such as the entanglement of historical and contemporary emotions in Henry's recounting of the Boston Massacre scene in *Assassin's Creed III*. Finally, I collapsed the axial codes into a theme that expressed a coherent narrative for each category. For example, the codes of "presence in" and "distance from" history combined into a broader theme of games providing a sense of immediate access to history that contrasted with students' perceptions of school-based learning.

Findings

My analysis showed that playing *Assassin's Creed* influenced students' perceptions of the past through a visceral sense of lived experience and empathetic engagement with characters. Students relished a sense of human connection with the past as they described becoming more aware of historical figures as people and more aware of historical perspectives they had not previously considered. As a result, many allowed *Assassin's Creed* to rewrite their school-based understanding of history, even when the games suggested a negative view of an event with which their contemporary identities intersected. Frequently contrasting their relationship to history through the games with their school-based associations of the topic, students perceived so many positives in their emotional engagement with *Assassin's Creed* that they often uncritically trusted that their gameplay experiences translated to real insight about the lived experiences of people in the past. Even as they theorized about the historical accuracy of *Assassin's Creed*, they often did so in a way that evidenced a great deal of trust in Ubisoft's game designers.

A sense of immediate access to history

Most students held reserved evaluations of their social studies classes and expressed moderate to low interest in the subject. They overwhelmingly associated the academic study of history with memorization. Alberto summarized, "Whenever we go through textbooks, it's like, this is how it happened. Exactly how it happened. Just make sure

you memorize this for the test.” Whereas this memorization-based approach left students feeling disengaged, *Assassin’s Creed* offered another way to appreciate the subject by providing what seemed to be a direct experience of history. Alessandro described school as “just sitting there, listening to one side of the story,” whereas with the games “you’re put into it” and “you have a chance to feel both sides.” Likewise, James explained that in classes, “it’s a lot of them telling us what happened and then we get to tell them what happened again” but that when playing *Assassin’s Creed*, “it’s not like you’re *learning* about [history]. You’re *experiencing* it.” Similarly, Charlie described a scene in *Unity*, a title set in the French Revolution, in which his character needed to escape the Bastille while riots were going on. Whereas he imagined his history teacher giving “a little lecture, saying, ‘Oh yeah, and there were people in the streets arguing, fighting, screaming,’” Charlie believed *Assassin’s Creed* had given him direct access to this historical moment: “You *actually* saw those people screaming and arguing and fighting in the streets.”

Just as Charlie described “actually seeing” people trying to survive the French Revolution, Henry indicated that it was not until he played *Assassin’s Creed III* that he realized there would have been screaming at the Boston Massacre. As a result, he “felt” the townspeople’s fear: “That was a terror not like anything I had ever read. But I *felt* that.” Henry explained how his relationship with his character on-screen was essential to this affective experience while playing: “You felt that because the game put you there, and you’re involved in this character. What he feels, too. Wherever he looks, you’re looking at the same place, feeling the same things.” In this way, Henry perceived that he had a seamless connection with his character and that the feelings he experienced via that character translated to understanding the likely emotions of people in history. For Henry, *Assassin’s Creed* provided an invitation to be emotionally present in the past.

Students thus emphasized both immersion and emotion as keys to this sense of experience that offered direct access to the past. None of these students stopped to problematize their visceral sense that they “actually saw” and “felt” what happened over the course of actual historical events. Rather, they focused on the great value they found in the way the games’ portrayal of history seemed immediate and rooted in human experience, especially when contrasted with academic experiences that felt disconnected and abstract. Gareth drew a lesson from this sense of virtual experience about history itself: “*Assassin’s Creed* reminds us that history is more than just words on a page. History is human experience. It allows you to experience it, instead of just reading about it.” Given that students voiced a sense of disconnection from the academic study of history, it is especially notable that *Assassin’s Creed* provided a sense of connection to the past which they valued strongly. However, while students vividly described a sense of being immersed in a historical time period as something they enjoyed, they did not problematize this feeling as something that might have unintended consequences for their understanding of the past.

This lack of reflection may have been in part because students did not perceive their gaming experiences as educational ones. The way the study of history was framed in school had an impact on what students perceived as legitimate forms of learning about history. For example, Adam so thoroughly associated learning history with memorization that he discounted experiences that did not involve direct recall. As a result, there was a certain cognitive dissonance in the way he recounted that, although he had studied the Byzantine Empire in school, it was only by playing *Revelations*, a title set in Constantinople, that he perceived the expanse of the empire: “I never really understood

much about the Byzantine Empire and how big they actually were, how powerful of an empire it was. The game gave me a decent scope of that.” Yet, while Adam seemed to indicate this portrayal added to his school-based understanding, his belief that learning history equated to memorizing names and dates led him to dismiss the educational value of this experience: “I think it’s definitely an interesting thing and a positive thing, what the game does and the vision it gives you. But from a history class standpoint, playing the games might give you some names and events, but it’s not really going to give you a whole lot of valuable historical info to use in that class.” Adam’s conclusion that there was not “a huge historical takeaway” may have made him less motivated to critically engage the portrayals he saw in *Assassin’s Creed*, including how they might consciously and unconsciously affect his beliefs about history. Other students tended to take their emotions while playing at face value, failing to subject them to critical analysis. The feeling of direct access to the past via the games may have added to the sense of the past they developed at school, but students generally did not see how their school-based analytical skills might transfer to their experiences with the games.

A sense of human connection

Students repeatedly emphasized that *Assassin’s Creed* helped them feel a sense of human connection to history, something they contrasted with their experiences in social studies classes. Todd could have been speaking for the group when he summarized, “The game does make you aware of the complexities of human nature, and humanity of people ... I don’t know if everyone else catches that same glimpse in a history class.”

At the most basic level, this sense of connection was achieved through the games’ portrayals of named historical figures. Students were often fascinated to “meet” famous people through the games and see them as human beings with personality traits unrelated to the actions for which they are remembered. Whereas reading about these figures in their history classes was something that felt abstract, interacting with a game character seemed to foster a sense of closeness with the historical figure on a human level. For example, Todd explained that “you don’t think of a person associated” with the historical figures he encountered in school: “In a history textbook, it’s just names, it’s just letters. You don’t really know. You just have a bullet point list of things that happened.” In contrast, Todd suggested that *Assassin’s Creed* “gives [historical figures] a voice. It gives them characteristics, quirks.” Similarly, Gareth gave the example of George Washington in *Assassin’s Creed III* as a contrast with the figure he had learned about in his textbook, which was heavily focused on “actions and the consequences of those actions.” Instead, Gareth explained that “in *Assassin’s Creed III* it was more like, this is who he is, this is his sternness, this is what he was concerned with, this is the way he addressed people. It changes him.” Gareth admitted that he didn’t expect “to find a section in my AP U.S. History textbook about, what was George Washington like? Did he like blackberries? Did he talk to his messengers, did he actually ask them questions about their families?” But this experience of witnessing a George Washington who engaged in everyday interactions with others was precisely the type of portrayal that made Gareth feel more connected to history. As Gareth described this vivid sense of emotional closeness to a historical figure, the boundaries between the game character and the historical figure became blurred. For Gareth, as for other students in the study, it seemed highly probable that the portrayals in

Assassin's Creed held the power to modify their beliefs about real historical figures. As Gareth concluded, *Assassin's Creed* was “a much more effective way” of learning about history than school-based classes because it offered chances for “connecting to different people as people, not words on a page, or not analysis.”

Students also described instances in which wholly fictional characters helped them connect with the humanity of people in the past. Here, the empathetic bonds students built with fictional characters frequently translated to increased empathy for the historical people represented by those characters. For example, Ethan described how the fictional character of Ratonhnhaké:ton/Connor prompted Ethan to reconsider what he thought he knew about Native Americans: “I got to be Connor and learned everything about his tribe and then I see that, oh wait, these people aren't really all that bad! They're not really all that different.” He candidly admitted that his previous impression of Native Americans was highly negative and dehumanizing (“I thought they were like barbaric, like, just beasts, fiendish”), something he traced back to his earliest memories of an “Indian” activity in preschool that involved what he termed “weird dancing.” In contrast, the character of Connor “brought me down to, wow, these people are not really that crazy ... I realized that they're actually kind of pretty humane if you think about it.” While Ethan may not have built a complex understanding of Native American cultures and history through *Assassin's Creed*, it was nevertheless significant that the games encouraged him to take the first empathetic step of not Othering these nations.

One of the most striking examples of a fictional character creating a sense of empathy with real historical peoples was recounted by Liam. In vivid detail, he described the way that playing as Adewalé in *Assassin's Creed: Freedom Cry* led him to credit a video game with being the first time he “saw how serious” slavery was:

I'd say one of the best, you know, where I got hit with the whole “how important it is to be free” and how much especially slaves need to be free, is in *Freedom Cry*. Because Adewalé was a slave, and then he escaped. In one of the missions, he has to dress up like a slave and actually go into a plantation. You know, to be all sneaky and stuff. But when his friend tells him, “You're going to have to dress up as a slave,” he loses his mind. He's like, “No, I'm not doing that again.” Like, “I'm not putting chains on myself.” Like, it's, “I'm just not.” I mean, he does do it eventually, but he's really unhappy about it. And that was the first time I— you see how serious this was, I'd say.

Here, the fictional character's portrayal of emotion was something Liam transferred to his imagination of the likely emotions of real enslaved people in history. Whereas Liam had studied slavery in school, what he had learned there felt abstract, concerned mostly with what he described as “a bunch of numbers and dates.” While Liam hastened to reassure me that he “was never put under the impression that [slavery] was a good thing,” he still wanted me to understand that it was this fictional portrayal that made him connect with the humanity of that history:

But with these games, you get a story. You get a character. With a name. And he has feelings. And you get to know him ... It made you realize how much this dominated their lives, and how much it mattered to them. Whereas, you know, like, “3 million slaves,” that doesn't tell me much in the heart. It doesn't make you know how that felt. Just that there were a lot of them.

Whereas theorizing in history education often uses the example of enslaved people to describe a trap of pity or sympathy rather than empathy, what Liam recounted here

avoided this problem entirely. Rather, entering into a narrative via a fictional character engendered an empathetic understanding that combined affect and cognition in the realization of “how much [freedom] mattered to [enslaved people].” Liam saw this emotional connection as a positive addition to the intellectual understanding he had developed at school. Significantly, Liam seemed to express that he wanted learning about history to be something that would, in his words, “tell [him] much in the heart.” He recognized the value of his school-based learning, but the abstract lessons he gleaned from the classroom were incomplete without this human sense of empathy as care.

While there were many positive aspects to the ways *Assassin's Creed* built this sense of human connection, it is nevertheless true that students accessed this new perspective not through historical evidence but via a popular, entertainment-based portrayal of history. This fact is of particular interest (and possibly concern) for social educators as the interactive nature of the game heightened students' feelings of empathy in striking ways. As Michael explained, playing as a first-person character gave him a sense of experiencing history firsthand: “It's like, ‘I did that.’ In a history book, it's all third-person pronouns, like ‘he did this,’ ‘she did that,’ ‘they did that.’ But here, you're seeing the famous historical figure, like: *oh my God, that's Alexander Hamilton!* Or like: *whoa! Ben Franklin is helping me!*” While Michael's enthusiasm for this star-struck feeling did indicate he valued this sense of connection to historical figures, it was also something he left unexamined as an emotion the game designers may have intentionally manufactured as part of the entertainment value of their product.

Perceiving multiple perspectives in history

For many students, playing *Assassin's Creed* was a catalyst for considering history from viewpoints they had not previously considered. Here, they frequently drew contrasts with their social studies classes, which they associated with more univocal narratives.

As Americans, these students were accustomed to considering the Revolutionary War from the perspective of colonists who chose to secede from Great Britain. In contrast, Alessandro said that *Assassin's Creed III* gave him the chance to “feel both sides” of the conflict: “When you're playing the game, you're put into it and you have a chance to feel both sides, as Royalists or Revolutionaries.” Likewise, Joseph felt he had gained a special insight while eavesdropping on British soldiers as part of gameplay:

You'll see how they talk, and sometimes you'll see that they sometimes were unsure of what they did. Near the end of the war, as an American person you never really thought of how afraid the British must have been that they were losing this war to somebody that they technically should have destroyed pretty handily, they just went about it wrong. But you can definitely see the other side of things.

Alberto similarly agreed that *Assassin's Creed* helped him understand the perspective of Loyalists during the American Revolution, something he said his history class had not offered him. For his part, Michael characterized the narrative he learned in his social studies classes as “the European White men who did it all by themselves!” and remarked that taking the role of Connor helped him perceive the problems with this narrative: “But it clearly isn't the case ... Playing as that minority character, even a fictional minority character, helps to show that.”

This new awareness of multiple perspectives, although fairly rudimentary, nevertheless held the power to trouble the narratives students knew from school. Aware that their history classes had tacitly encouraged them to relate to the American side of the conflict, students took the presence of alternate perspectives in *Assassin's Creed* as proof of an impartial and trustworthy portrayal of history. For example, George described the way the games frequently positioned the main character as adjacent to a conflict but not on either side (Connor's ambivalence about helping American colonists is one example of this plot technique). George perceived these seemingly neutral main characters as offering a particularly unbiased opportunity to perceive multiple viewpoints in history:

You're not on either side, so you see both sides for what actions they do. So if they're good, they do nice things. And I don't think either of them really does anything nice. They are just bad, both sides seem kind of bad. So you don't see the history through the lens of who you want to win, or through the lens of who wins. Like, "history is written by the winners," that's not really apparent in *Assassin's Creed*.

For George, who was accustomed to history classes that celebrated the American side of the Revolutionary War, this portrayal of multiple, ambiguous perspectives marked a way in which the games offered a "less biased" narrative. Adam similarly suggested that that history textbooks were "heavily influenced by who were the big dogs of history," whereas *Assassin's Creed* "gives you different insights on what else was going on in that time period." Likewise, Gareth was struck by the way *Assassin's Creed* presented both the Americans and British as trying to manipulate Native American nations. As a result, he came to a view of the Revolution that was more complex:

It's not so clear-cut. It's not good versus evil. It is this mix of many different things of economics, of government, of simple relations between people. Of this balancing game between beliefs of different groups and how that affects alliances. How it affects actions. How it affects worldviews.

Joseph offered an example of this moral ambiguity, remarking on how his history classes described battles in terms of strategic impacts but that *Assassin's Creed* gave him a sense of the human cost of war:

In history [class], you don't get to see the scope of death. In Lexington and Concord you don't get to see people laying on the ground when the battle's not even around them and they were just left there because no one had time to pick them up, they had to keep moving. You don't see that in your history books. You just learn about the main British official dying, and them winning.

In contrast, from his vantage point within the game, Joseph was able to see "the people dying all over the ground" as well as the townspeople's reaction when they came out after the battle to see the bodies left behind. Accustomed to hearing about famous generals, this portrayal of anonymous soldiers and townspeople—the kind of people Joseph realized must have existed in history but whose perspectives had not been explored in his history class—prompted reflection. As a result, Joseph concluded that *Assassin's Creed* was "more honest" than his social studies class.

Overall, students were enchanted by the novelty of perceiving historical perspectives that had not been explored in their classes at school. They seemed to believe that what

they saw of these viewpoints was trustworthy, despite not knowing the outside information that might corroborate or contradict the games' narrative. While 11 of the 14 participants said the games had inspired them to conduct online searches to learn more about something they saw in the games, the information they looked for tended to be relatively simple facts (e.g., James's search for whether the Janissaries had really existed) compared to the complex information needed to reconstruct a historical perspective. However, this lack of follow-through may not have been due to a lack of curiosity on their part. Having experienced a formal history education that emphasized memorization of facts presented as certainties, it was unclear whether students were aware that historians had developed techniques for investigating the type of ambiguities raised by multiple historical perspectives. As such, they may not have known how to access the kind of research that would have extended their understanding of questions they found so compelling within the games. In this way, the univocal nature of their school experiences may have made the games more alluring, as they offered students the tantalizing sense that there was more to the story than they had been told.

Rewriting their sense of history and themselves

At times, *Assassin's Creed* confronted students with surprising portrayals of historical groups or moments that intersected with their contemporary identities. Although students' personal connections to the history at hand might have been expected to prompt defensive reactions, the games' ability to foster a sense of direct access to history and empathetic connection to historical figures resulted in students internalizing these unexpected and often negative portrayals. As a result, the games held the power to rewrite their understandings of history and even reshape their understandings of themselves.

For example, while playing *Assassin's Creed III*, Ethan experienced both a shift in his understanding of the historical figure of George Washington and his understanding of himself as an American. Ethan was struck by the plot point in which Washington ordered that the village of the main character's tribe be burned. This action was unexpected from Ethan's point of view and made him rethink what he thought he knew about the historical figure of Washington: "I thought he was The American Hero, like, perfect, nothing was wrong with him. That was when I started to realize that, hey, maybe all these characters aren't really perfect, and there's a lot of flaws with them." Ethan explained that his previous image of Washington came from his social studies class, which had promoted a heroic, "perfect" image: "George Washington, social studies class taught me just everything that was good about him. And almost fantasizes him about being this great guy, didn't ever do anything wrong." In contrast, Ethan said *Assassin's Creed* "shows everything about him." He felt there was value in combining the games and classes as sources for his understanding of Washington: "I can use what I learned in social studies class and then the video game adds a different perspective to who he is and what he is." Here, Ethan suggested *Assassin's Creed* served as a corrective to his social studies class by providing ballast to heroizing portrayals of a famous figure. While a social educator well versed in American history would be able to recognize the validity of Ethan's revised understanding of Washington, it is significant that Ethan made this leap without seeking the outside information that could have corroborated the game's account. Instead, Ethan trusted the

games so thoroughly that he accepted its portrayal of Washington even when it contradicted what he thought he knew.

Just as *Assassin's Creed* changed Ethan's view of George Washington, it also gave him a different impression of Americans during the Revolution. He explained, "It definitely changed my perspective a lot. Because it brought it down to dirty, gritty parts of the Revolution, rather than the formal battles that we learned in grade school." He seemed particularly struck by the game's portrayal of interactions between American colonists and British soldiers:

I remember some part in which the British soldier is standing there and all these Americans are talking bad on him ... I was confused because I thought the British people were the ones that were almost the owners of the Americans. They were talking all the trash, quote-unquote. But it turns out that it was both sides.

Here again, Ethan accepted the *Assassin's Creed* portrayal of Revolutionary-era Americans without outside corroboration, even though it seemed confusing and unexpected to him at first. This easy acceptance had consequences, as it prompted reflection on his own identity as an American. He explained, "Growing up in America, I was really nationalistic. I thought 'America's the best!' and 'We never do anything wrong!' But this game showed me that we're not the perfect people that I thought we were." Here, *Assassin's Creed* held the power to reshape Ethan's understanding of himself as an American.

Similarly, Liam talked at length about the depiction of Pope Alexander VI (born Rodrigo Borgia) as the main villain in *Assassin's Creed II*. As a Catholic, Liam described growing up with messages that the Church consistently acted toward the good. In contrast, *Assassin's Creed II* presented him with a story of corruption and deceit in the pursuit of power. He was so struck by this portrayal that he researched the history of the Borgia family on his own, a process that confirmed the *Assassin's Creed* storyline. Although this outside verification mattered to him, the game's ability to foster a sense of connection to its characters was key for Liam's willingness to reconsider what he thought he knew. Liam said his changed view of the Renaissance from "a great time of Europe being reborn" to a time when "there are people who are not nice and cutting, killing their way through life and taking power" was rooted in the portrayal of Pope Alexander VI as a character with whom he held a personal connection as a Catholic. Liam said he might have resisted hearing about historical instances of Church corruption "a little bit more than I'd like to admit" if the message had been conveyed to him as historical analysis. In contrast, *Assassin's Creed* presented him with a character he related to first as a human being, and then was confronted with the results of his actions:

For awhile they just say, here's a bad guy ... and you'll watch him do these terrible things. And at the end, it's like, aaaand he's the pope! So at this point like they've shown you how terrible he is, and you've been agreeing with it, that you can't resist the fact that he's a pope. Which is good, you know, you shouldn't resist the fact that a pope can be such a terrible person.

Liam concluded that it was "dangerous" for any organization to have "as much power as the Church did in Europe at that time." This belief marked a radical change from his earlier view that the Church consistently acted toward the greater good, and one phrased in a way that implied that he was drawing wider lessons that might apply in other situations as well. Liam's story suggested that, while a school-based approach might

emphasize changing students' minds through analysis of evidence, the resistance often engendered by this pedagogical technique could melt in the face of a human portrayal.

Finally, students' willingness to allow *Assassin's Creed* to rewrite their understandings of history and reshape their understandings of themselves could also prompt reflections on their school-based social studies experiences. For example, *Assassin's Creed* gave Alberto a different perspective on the Crusades than he had learned in his Catholic grade school. Whereas he had implicitly been taught to sympathize with the Crusaders, *Assassin's Creed* had him step into a different role through the character of Altaïr Ibn-La'Ahad, a Syrian Assassin who lived during the Third Crusade. Alberto described being disconcerted by what he saw through Altaïr's eyes: "You really see just how terrible these Europeans were. Like, coming in, they're really terrible to the people there." He explained, "Playing the game you're ... battling against the Crusaders ... there are parts where they just kill these people just walking past ... they really don't do much to support the area." This portrayal was not only different from what he had learned in social studies classes but was also powerful enough to prompt questioning of his school experience. Alberto reflected,

In Catholic grade school, we didn't talk about the Crusades as being as detrimental to the people in that area as I guess we could have ... we were taught that they were going back to reclaim the Holy Land, and that it was a noble quest. When I guess in *Assassin's Creed* you see it more as pointless. Like, just killing for killing. And then really no actual point behind it.

Here, the portrayal of Crusaders in *Assassin's Creed* held the power to rewrite Alberto's understanding of history, even one that he associated with his religion. Like Ethan, he did not need outside corroboration of the Crusaders' cruelty; he trusted the games enough to let them open a rift in his faith in his school experience.

Theorizing about historical accuracy

Participants were aware that *Assassin's Creed* was a created narrative. However, as they described this awareness, they nearly always did so in ways that indicated a great deal of trust in the design process. For example, Joseph described how Ubisoft made use of "a full force of historians" to find competing views so that they can "create a collective view of what they know and they'll put it in to the game." Alessandro expressed confidence in the designers, saying "I'm sure the researchers at Ubisoft spent a lot of time figuring out what daily life was like" and enthused, "It's amazing just how Ubisoft does it with just putting you in there and how things are so accurate with what they do." Incorporating an awareness of the game as an entertainment product, Adam reflected,

I think it is surprising, how much historical accuracy is involved ... obviously they're making a game, so they have to add different story and things that pull you in and add fun value to the history of it. But then [it] also keeps somewhat with a rough timeline of the events that were happening of that time. So I think it's pretty interesting to look back and see, wow, a lot of this stuff really did happen.

Students also tended to trust the designers to present an unbiased view of history. George interpreted the opening screen at the beginning of *Assassin's Creed* that tells players the game was developed "by a multicultural team of various religious faiths and beliefs" as providing proof of neutrality. Reflecting on the possibility for bias, Gareth said video games represented a medium in which designers "don't necessarily have an agenda, other

than to broaden people's ideas of what happened." He estimated that Ubisoft did "a pretty good job of appearing pretty unbiased" because they showed how "the good people that we see in history do bad things."

Students often contrasted this portrayal of moral ambiguity with the heroizing narratives they frequently encountered in their social studies classes. Todd found that *Assassin's Creed* was "more honest" than his history class because it encouraged him to perceive greater complexity in history: Whereas history class "passes over [the bad parts] without really thinking about it," *Assassin's Creed* "begs the question for you to examine it." Believing that adults would likely resist his reports of a video game having such an impact on the way he thought about history, Todd acknowledged that he could understand "where the teachers are coming from" in worries that the games might "indoctrinate a student to think history is concrete" or believe that "interpretations cannot be questioned." However, Todd emphasized this was not the case in his engagement with *Assassin's Creed* and questioned why his teachers did not similarly encourage him to be skeptical of his textbook. Likewise, Alberto observed that while reading his textbook, his focus was on absorbing information uncritically, whereas the presence of fictional characters in *Assassin's Creed* made him more cautious:

In *Assassin's Creed*, I definitely know that some characters are fictional and some are real. You have to ask yourself, which one is real, which one's fictional? And definitely for some of the people, were they really like this? Or was this something they would actually do?

When I asked George to sort characters into "historical" and "fictional" groups, he impressed upon me that there was a difference between the historical George Washington and the fictional portrayal of George Washington in *Assassin's Creed* and suggested that the game character should be seen as "both historical and fictional" as a result.

Taken together, these data indicate that students were aware of *Assassin's Creed* as a created narrative and exercised some degree of agency in their evaluations of its accuracy. However, while they acknowledged the game was created for entertainment, students evinced a nearly unquestioning faith that Ubisoft's designers were scrupulously presenting an accurate, unbiased view of history. They did not integrate concerns that market demands might shape the narratives presented, nor that this impact might lead to certain aspects of history being amplified or "occluded" (Wineburg, Mosburg, Porat, & Duncan, 2007, p. 66).

Discussion

As students reflected on their interactions with *Assassin's Creed*, it was clear that their gameplay experiences had fostered certain components of historical empathy as understood by Barton and Levstik's (2004) two-part definition of historical empathy as perspective recognition and care. With regard to historical empathy as perspective recognition, *Assassin's Creed* proved well suited to fostering the components of "shared normalcy" and "multiplicity of historical perspectives." For example, Ethan cast off his previously held, dehumanizing stereotypes of Native Americans and Joseph became more aware of the perspectives of British Loyalists during the American Revolution. With regard to historical empathy as care, *Assassin's Creed* proved a strong ground for exercising skills in *caring that* (i.e., forming a basis for making moral judgments about what

happened) and *caring for* (i.e., establishing a sense of compassion for people in the past), as the empathetic bonds students built with fictional characters frequently translated to increased empathy for the historical people represented by those characters. For example, Liam described a profound deepening of his understanding of the evils of slavery and its impact on enslaved peoples via the character of Adewalé. Further, the skill of *caring to* (i.e., developing a willingness to apply what has been learned from history to the present) was indirectly present in students' willingness to reconsider histories that intersected with their contemporary identities. For example, Alberto rejected his Catholic school's view of the Crusades after playing as the game character Altaïr Ibn-La'Ahad. Finally, the highly immersive settings that sparked students' imaginations, paired with the thrill of "meeting" famous historical figures, spurred on their experiences of empathy as *caring about* (i.e., being able to identify what one wants to learn about in history). Even on the most basic level, students became curious about "what was real" in the game and frequently conducted online searches to confirm or disprove what they saw on-screen.

Yet, students' learning could have gone further. While *Assassin's Creed* may be a powerful tool for fostering certain aspects of historical empathy, it remains an incomplete one. In particular, it was less adept at helping students achieve the "historical contextualization" and "contextualization of the present" components of Barton and Levstik's (2004) definition of historical empathy as perspective recognition. As contextualization is at the root of grasping ways in which our contemporary beliefs may differ from the ways historical people understood their own experiences in their own time, it is perhaps unsurprising that the games failed to develop the "sense of otherness" skill as well. For example, Henry's description of feeling "a terror not like anything [he] had ever read" during the Boston Massacre scene promoted a sense of emotional connection between himself and people in the past, but it did not build his curiosity about ways in which the meanings historical people ascribed to the event might differ from his own contemporary assessment. Instead, he felt a seamless connection to the past, trusting that *his* gameplay experience was a window into *their* feelings. In this sense, it was a double-edged sword that the games' narrative structure proved exceptionally useful for achieving gains in shared normalcy. This blade is particularly sharp in that students in this study so deeply valued their newfound recognition of a shared humanity with people in the past that their emotions tied to the games and their emotions tied to historical figures often became entangled. In this regard, students who play *Assassin's Creed* without applying skills in critical analysis may risk reifying a tendency toward presentism.

However, for students to apply the critical inquiry skills they learn in their social studies classes, they must first recognize the games as eligible for such analysis. Here, *Assassin's Creed's* status as a "neglected media" (Reichmuth & Werning, 2006, p. 47) poses considerable difficulties for the purposes of social education: When given messages that video games are not to be taken seriously, students may internalize their messages without subjecting them to serious analysis. A case study in this regard was found in Adam, who repeatedly dismissed any suggestion that *Assassin's Creed* might be a worthy site for critical engagement. Perhaps as a result, his interview responses were markedly shorter and less detailed than those of students like Liam and Gareth, whose lengthy responses showed they had been thinking deeply about the games for some time. While Adam's outright rejection of a popular culture source may have seemed more respectable to traditionally minded educators, it also meant that he missed an opportunity to

demonstrate his historical understanding by exercising his criticality in a robust way. In contrast, Liam and Gareth's ability to articulate their reasoning showed a higher level of skill.

In this regard, this study provides evidence for the validity of narrative video games with historical settings as a site for social education research. For students in this study, taking part in such a narrative via virtual characters and settings had a strong influence on their beliefs about the past. The students often believed they had gained a direct window on historical experience and that gameplay meant seeing and even feeling the same thing as historical people—a result in line with contemporary research in psychology investigating the way the brain processes the immersive nature of video game experience (i.e., the profound impression of “having actually been there” fostered by the virtual environment's impact on spatial presence). As social educators in the twenty-first century, our ability to promote historical reasoning may well be tied to our knowledge of effective ways to encourage criticality with virtual experiences that feel visceral.

Additionally, students in this study took the presence of multiple perspectives to be proof of impartiality and tended to be alternately unaware of or highly trusting of Ubisoft's hand in designing a particular vision of the past. Research in public history may help explain this dynamic. In Rosenzweig and Thelen's (1998) landmark study, *The Presence of the Past*, Americans rated sources that, to them, seemed unmediated—such as museums with authentic artifacts and relatives alive during a historical event—as much more trustworthy than academic sources such as history professors, social studies teachers, or nonfiction books. This principle appears to be activated in *Assassin's Creed*, as students in this study regularly spoke in ways that indicated a sense they had “actually” been in historical times and places, rather than experiencing an artistic representation. When asked to consciously reflect on this feeling, most students did not adopt a critical view but instead indicated a high level of trust in Ubisoft's design team. Thus, as Ubisoft continues to target social studies classrooms with its new “discovery tour” mode, the social education community needs to develop ways to help students become aware of the constructed nature of this media and critically analyze the strengths and weaknesses of its portrayals.

Further, this study illustrates how our knowledge of the impact of video games, still in relatively early stages, should not be limited to only those games whose mechanisms are most easily harnessed toward conventional learning goals. *Assassin's Creed* does not lend itself to building an easily testable series of names and dates in students' minds, nor does it teach causation in the manner of a simulation game like *Civilization*. Yet, as this study shows, the narrative structure of *Assassin's Creed* can and does exercise a profound impact on students' historical imaginations. The franchise may well be impractical to implement in the classroom, whether due to time limitations, financial expense, or concerns about portrayals of violence. However, this step is unnecessary, as *Assassin's Creed* already has an impact on millions of students in their out-of-school hours—with Ubisoft's marketing team targeting ever-younger audiences (Sinclair, 2014). We need to know how to help students critically engage with the media *they are already consuming of their own accord*. As such, *Assassin's Creed* is a case study for how the messages students receive about history do not stop at the classroom door.

All this said, the case of *Assassin's Creed* also has something to offer the ways we approach history within the classroom. Students in this study evinced a hunger for a feeling of human connection to people in the past and were enthralled by their sense of

discovering previously hidden viewpoints. The attention commanded by the mundane gameplay mechanics of fighting and killing paled in comparison to their appetite for a novel, empathetic way to enter into an immersive historical environment—an observation corroborated by the many online fan fora and publications that dedicate themselves not to celebrating portrayals of violence but rather to cataloguing and debating the games’ narrative arcs. Yet, for students in this study, this passion for imagining the past did not translate to their history classes, which they overwhelmingly associated with memorization.

Thus, it is significant that, while a substantial vein of research is dedicated to improving history instruction by focusing on the development of important critical thinking skills through engagement with primary sources, we know less about how to meet students’ affective need for a sense of human connection. How do we respond to students like Liam, who wanted history to “tell [him] much in the heart”? His earnest words represent a hunger for meaning that goes to the heart of social education. As Barton and Levstik (2004) argued,

We cannot interest students in the study of history—something they enjoy outside of school but often despise within it—if we reject their cares and concerns or if we dismiss their feeling and emotions. Moreover, without care, we could not possibly engage them in humanistic study: Students will not bother making reasoned judgments, expanding their views of humanity, or deliberating over the common good if they don’t care about those things. (pp. 228–229)

In this way, the case of *Assassin’s Creed* contains lessons for teachers who will never pick up a game controller. What do we have to offer to students like Gareth, for whom the image of a George Washington who enjoyed eating blackberries felt like a revelation? The point is, of course, not whether a historical figure’s culinary tastes are supported by the evidentiary record but to recognize what this vignette says about what students are *not* learning in many classrooms. Otherwise stated, what would it mean to keep humanity at the center of our discipline? Rather than rejecting the affective domain outright, we might find ways to teach toward historical empathy as perspective recognition and care in an intellectually robust way that establishes a sense of human connection while avoiding the trap of presentism. To do so may represent an important expansion of criticality that stands to help students tie together the cognitive and the affective as they bridge the gap between their experiences with history, both in school and beyond the classroom walls.

Conclusion

Video games are significant in many students’ lives but lack a significant space in the social education literature. The few studies which do exist tend to focus on content transmission and emphasize the importance of teacher mediation. As a result, little is known about the meanings that students independently construct as they consume this form of media. This study has offered some insight into this problem by surfacing the richness of students’ unmediated engagement with a popular video game series. Far from treating games as mindless entertainment, students in this study thought deeply about the portrayals of historical peoples and events they encountered in *Assassin’s Creed*. They felt a human sense of connection to historical figures and valued the ways the games made them more aware of multiple perspectives in history. Through their narrative structure,

the games held the power to change students' views of time periods and prompt reflection on the relevance of history to the students' contemporary identities. However, students also missed opportunities for critical engagement with their visceral sense of immersion in the past and often did not perceive ways in which the academic study of history might have extended their understanding of questions they found compelling within the games. In this way, this study has revealed ways that social educators might learn from *Assassin's Creed* even as they teach students to be more critical consumers of the medium. Further research on the ways that students utilize such games may offer insights not only into students' practices of meaning making and identity construction outside the classroom but also into the importance of fostering a human sense of connection to history through social education.

Note

1. It is worth noting that empirical research has demonstrated a lack of connection between playing violent video games and engaging in violent behavior (Kühn et al., 2018a, 2018b; Zendle, Kudenko, & Cairns, 2018).

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Appendix: Interview protocol

What grade are you in? What social studies classes have you taken?

Here's the list I have of *Assassin's Creed* games you've played. Does it look right to you?

What's the difference between the Assassins and the Templars? Do their beliefs influence the role they play in how history unfolds? Do you think something similar happens in the course of real history (how so)?

Tell me about the American Revolution from Connor's perspective. How is this story the same or different from what you learned in school?

Here's a list of places where Connor was during the Revolutionary War. Pick one of them that you remember well. How did his actions there influence the course of the war?

Here's a list of Assassins. Can you put them into chronological order?

Here are the names of characters that appeared in *III*. Can you sort these into historical and fictional groups? What can you tell me about Samuel Adams?

Here are two passages about the Boston Massacre, one from the *Assassin's Creed* encyclopedia and the other from a high school history textbook. Is one of them more interesting than the other? Why/how so? Is one of them more accurate than the other? Why/how so?

Has anything in *Assassin's Creed* made you see a historical time period differently from how you thought about it before? (*If yes*: Tell me about that. Where do you think you got your original ideas about that time period? What do you think *Assassin's Creed* did that was successful in changing your mind about that time period?)

Has something from your social studies class ever made you see something in *Assassin's Creed* differently? (*If yes*: Tell me about that.)

If you could go back in time and be any Assassin you wanted, would you do it? Who would you want to be and why? If you could go back in time and live in any time period, but as a regular person, would you do it? Who or when would you want to be and why (why not)?

What's more honest about history, *Assassin's Creed* or your history class? How so?

Has something you've learned from *Assassin's Creed* ever helped you in a social studies class? Tell me about that.

Have you ever Googled something you saw in *Assassin's Creed* to find out if it was historically accurate? Tell me about that.